

Deadly duo: Saurav Ghosal had won a mixed doubles silver with Dipika Pallikal in the 2018 CWG in Gold Coast. Ghosal wants to do one better at the next edition. GETTY IMAGES

In terms of qualification criteria, nothing is official. Surely, there'll be a route available through the PSA rankings — a quota — but this door is closed for me. There is a good chance that there will be some sort of regional quota. So maybe the Asian Games will be a qualification route. These might be clear only close to 2026. For me, playing any tournament for India has never been about just being there; I want to do something where I feel like I can genuinely try to win something. I know that I won't have that ranking; I won't have the constant match practice against the top guys, which is going to be a hindrance. But I feel like, at this stage in my career, the most important thing for me is that my body and my mind have to be in the best shape possible, and for that to happen in '28, playing 18 tournaments a year for the next four years, we're pushing the rock high uphill to make that possible. This way, the workload is a lot lower, and I have a lot longer to recover between tournaments.

Last year, during the Nationals, we spoke to a few players to find out what needs to be focussed on now that the sport is headed to the Olympics. Some of them asked for better sparring partners, more Challenger events, and the like. What are your thoughts?

One thing that can get better is the quality of expertise available in India. We don't quite have what's needed to produce someone who's going to make the top 20 or top 30 in the world. There is a reason why I go to David (Palmer) and James (Willstrop), right? There's a reason why Ramit (Tandon) is in New York quite a bit; there's a reason why Velavan (Senthilkumar), a national champion right now, goes to Barcelona. We would love to stay in Chennai or somewhere in India for the most part. That's a lot easier. That is where



we have to try to fill the void a little bit. The higher you go, there are a lot of subtleties in the game that have to be kind of relayed to the players because they, at least, have to have recognition of those aspects. They might not have the skills right away to execute those abilities, but if they have no recognition, then they won't even try to execute those bits.

Reflecting on your PSA tour career of over two decades, do you have any regrets or any unfulfilled goals?

The only one that stands out for me is that I wanted to make single digits in the rankings, perhaps make the top five. The rankings work in such a way that you need a few matches to go your way. There have been a few matches over the last four or five years where I've been up against some of the top guys and have been very close to winning them, the last one probably being against Diego at the World Championships last year in Chicago. If you win these kinds of matches, the draw opens up a lot more. If you have one or two good tournaments like that, suddenly, from like 12–13 in the world, you're up to eight, nine at least, if not higher. That would be the one thing that I wish had fallen into place for me. Having said that, when I began playing squash at eight, I didn't even know what PSA was; I didn't even know it existed till I was 15–16, and at that point in time, no Indian had ever made the top 50 in the world. When I was 18, Ritwik (Bhattacharya) was ranked 38 in the

world, which was the highest. At that point, I thought, "Well, no one's made the top 30 in the world. So, let's do it." If I had to go back and look at myself as a kid and someone told me that I would finish with whatever I have right now, I would have beaten the hand off and said 'thank you very much' and then walked away. As a human, you always want more, but you also have to be grateful for everything that has happened. and I'm thankful for that.

What is your vision now?

The Asian Games is definitely on the list. I would love to win the individual gold. I'm very fortunate to have the two team goals. That's something that, growing up, I wanted to have. If I can make it to the Asiad, and if I can get two medals, it will take me up to 11 medals, which will equal P.T. Usha's haul at the Games. It will be nice to have a squash player on the list with someone like her who's done unbelievable things herself. The individual medal at the Commonwealth Games was a big thing, and if I can better that, then great.

One thing that would be nice is for Dipika (Pallikal) and me to win gold in the mixed doubles. We have won silver and bronze, and it would be nice to win gold too. If everything works out and the Olympics happens, just getting there would be an achievement. But if we win a medal, it would trump everything else. These are the things that keep me up at night.